

## ERGONOMICS

### Task 4

Tony: There are a number of health and safety problems that may result from the continuous use of computers. Anyone spending more than four hours a day working on a PC may start to suffer from aching hands, neck or shoulders, occasional headaches, and eyestrain.

Worker one: Is there anything we can do to avoid it?

Tony: Yes, there's a lot you can do. For example, if you take the trouble to position your computer properly, you can avoid backache. Get a good chair, one that supports your lower back and is adjustable so you can change its height and angle. Make sure your feet rest firmly on the floor or on a footrest. Position the keyboard at the same height as your elbows, with your arms parallel to the work surface, and position the monitor at or just below eye level. You should look down at it slightly, not up. Don't put your monitor in front of a window, and make sure there isn't a lamp shining directly into your eyes or reflecting off the screen. You should sit at arm's length from the front of the monitor – about 50 to 70 centimetres away. It's a good idea to have a monitor with a tilt-and-swivel stand. Does anyone know what that is?

Worker two: Yes. I think it's a kind of stand that lets you move the monitor up or around, so you can use it at the correct angle and height.

Tony: That's right. Now, do you know of any health problems caused by using a computer?

Worker three: I've heard of something called RSI. But I'm not exactly sure what it is.

Tony: RSI stands for *repetitive strain injury*, and it causes pain in the upper arms and back. People who type constantly at high speed often suffer from it.

Worker four: My eyes often feel really sore and tired after I've been using the computer for a few hours. How do I stop that from happening?

Tony: Well, as a general rule, you shouldn't use a monitor that's fuzzy or that distorts the image. Give your eyes a rest. Look away from the monitor from time to time out of the window or across the room.

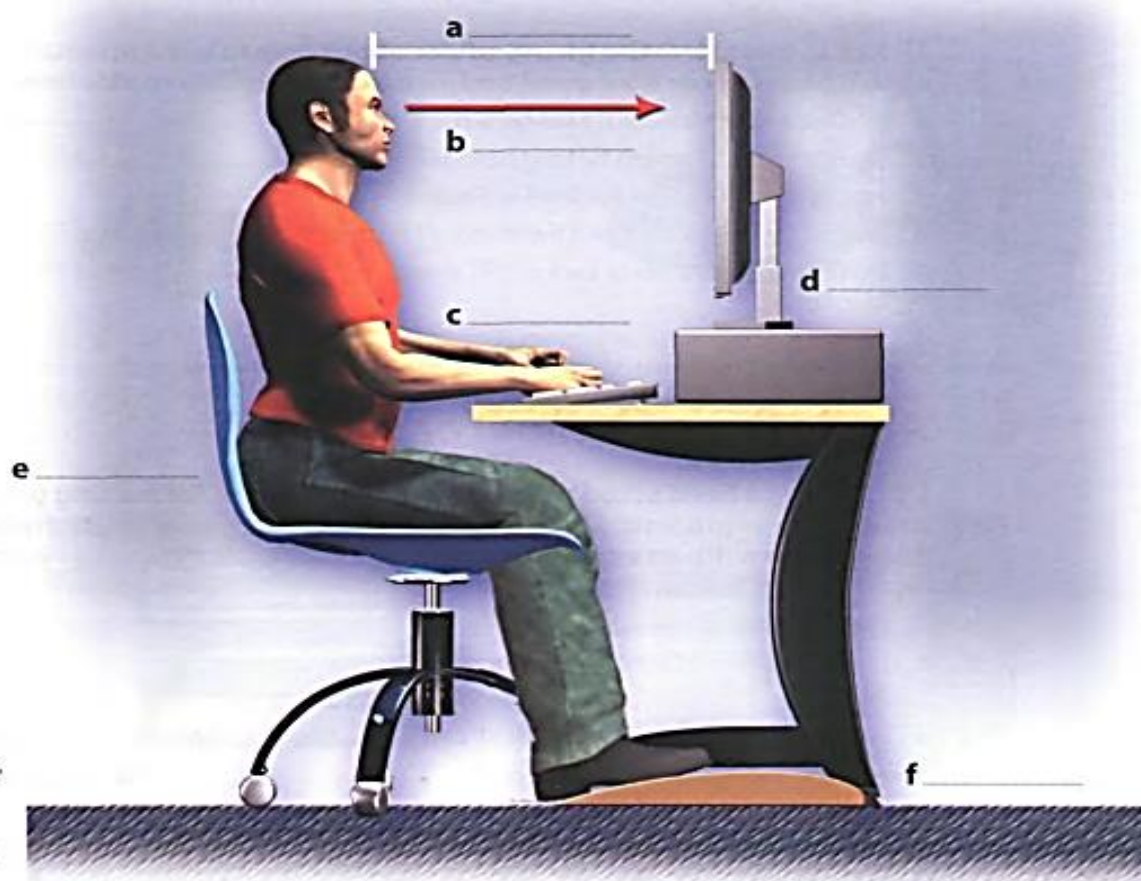
## 4 Ergonomics

**A**  Listen to Tony Clark, an expert in computer ergonomics, talking to some office workers about health and safety. What health problems associated with computer use do the office workers mention?

**B**  Listen again and complete these extracts.

- 1 Get a good chair, one that \_\_\_\_\_ your lower back and is \_\_\_\_\_.
- 2 Make sure your feet rest firmly \_\_\_\_\_ or on a footrest.
- 3 Position the keyboard \_\_\_\_\_ your elbows, with your arms \_\_\_\_\_ the work surface ...
- 4 ... position the monitor at, or just below, \_\_\_\_\_.
- 5 You should sit at \_\_\_\_\_ from the front of the monitor, about 50 to 70 centimetres away.
- 6 ... a kind of stand that lets you move the monitor \_\_\_\_\_, so you can use it at the correct angle and height.

**C** Match the extracts above (1–6) with the correct parts of the diagram (a–f).



*Ergonomics – the study of how people interact safely and efficiently with machines and their work conditions*